Little Fox Readers

Level 5

Journey to the West 103

The Land of the West



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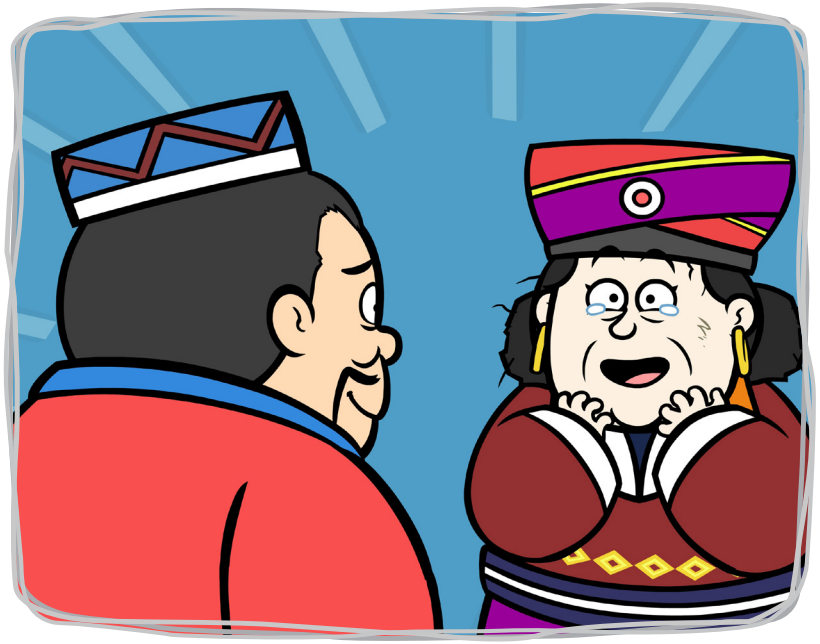


Wukong returned from the Land of Darkness. Lady Kou brought the travelers back to her house. Inside the coffin the squire's body was gray and lifeless.

Wukong leaned over the coffin and recited a spell. Lady Kou gasped as color returned to her husband's face.

"It's working!" said Wujing.

"The squire is coming back to life!" said



the Tang Monk.

Bajie licked his lips. "Maybe the squire will thank us with a big feast."

Squire Kou sat up and smiled. "Thank you, Wukong." He climbed out of the coffin and turned to his wife. Tears filled her eyes. The two embraced.

That night Squire and Lady Kou held a feast to thank Wukong. And the next morning



they let the travelers leave without any argument.

"Good luck!" called Lady Kou as they departed.

* * *

The Tang Monk and his companions traveled for many more months. Through rain and snow, heat and cold, they slowly continued west.



One day the road went into a beautiful land. There were flowers and magnificent trees. People smiled at the travelers and offered food.

The Tang Monk stared in amazement. "What is this place?"

"We are in the west," said Wukong. "We are very close to the Western Paradise."

A woman held out a basket of plums.



Bajie scooped up a handful. “I love this place.”

“Look up ahead,” said Wujing, pointing to a row of tall buildings. “It’s an abbey.”

The road led through a large gate in the abbey.

At the gate the monk got down from his horse. A young man greeted them.

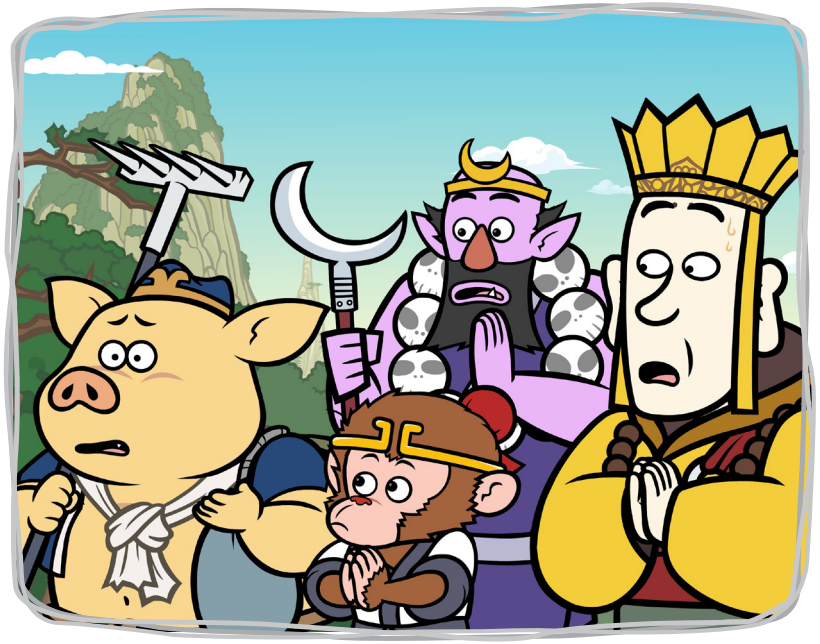
“Are you the Tang Monk?” asked the man.



“Yes,” said the monk. He waved toward the rest of the group. “And these are my companions.”

“You’ve finally arrived!” The man laughed. “I was starting to think that the bodhisattva Guanyin had tricked me. She told me you would arrive in a year or so. But that was over ten years ago!”

The Tang Monk bowed. “Forgive me. I



wanted to arrive much sooner. But we faced many dangers and delays along the way."

Bajie snorted. "And this place wasn't very easy to find either."

The man smiled. "There is no need to apologize. I'm the Great Immortal of the Golden Head, and this abbey is my home. Behind it lies the Western Paradise. Come inside and rest before you continue."



Servants filled tubs with warm perfumed water, and the travelers took baths.

"It feels good to get clean," said Bajie. "I haven't had a bath in months."

Wukong laughed. "Now we won't have to cover our noses when you're near!"

Bajie snorted and splashed water at Wukong. The monkey splashed back. Everyone laughed.

After their baths the Tang Monk put on the



Buddhist robe Guanyuin had given him. Then the travelers enjoyed a large meal with the immortal. Servants brought trays loaded with noodles, vegetables, tofu, and steamed buns.

In the morning the immortal led the group out the back door of the abbey. The road continued west, through a land even more beautiful and magical. Birds sang as animals leaped playfully through the flowers. Brilliant



light sparkled on everything. In the distance stood a huge mountain. Its peak was hidden by clouds.

The Tang Monk stared silently at the mountain.

Wukong put his hand on the monk's shoulder. "That's the Spirit Mountain, Master. We're almost at the end of our journey."

A smile spread across the monk's face.



The travelers thanked the immortal. Filled with energy now, they hurried down the road. The steep slopes of the Spirit Mountain towered over them.